

through the same peon. It was not possible to manage all the peons in broking firms.

There was a solution to this problem too. The FII activity data from all custodians had to be finally filed with SEBI. If I could manage to befriend somebody in the FII department, all the important deals would be at my fingertips. It took me nearly three months, but using my friends-of-friends networks, I finally managed to crack a low-ranking official in that all-important department. I was now set for the big league, or so I thought, since nobody could have the kind of data I would have access to.

The SEBI records did not mention whether the trade was a 'buy' or a 'sell'; instead, it mentioned '1' against a buy trade and '2' against a sell trade. The 1-2 data, as it would be known in market parlance after some months, was the most sacrosanct of all data on FII activity.

I used to pay that official Rs 5,000 every month for the information. I mentally named him 'Mouse' because he would dig out information whenever I requested him to. Our deal was that he would pass me information on a few important trades every day and on certain deals that I would specifically ask for. I never told anybody where I was getting my information from, not even GB or Prakash, the two people I trusted most.

One day, Lucky offered to take me out for a drink in the evening. He suggested White House at Tardeo. I agreed, more out of curiosity than anything else, having heard about that place from so many fellow traders.

The place was dimly lit, but not too crowded for that hour of the evening. We took a table very close to the dance floor where a bunch of overdressed and over-made-up girls were swaying to a 1980s hit number. Lucky called for drinks, and changed a couple of hundreds for crisp tenners to be fired away at the dancers. A few patrons glanced at me, perhaps trying to size me up. Call it my imagination or nerves, but I felt everybody was staring at me. I had been to many bars, but this was the first time I had set foot in a dance bar.

One person looking my way struck me as a market operator Lucky had been pestering me to meet, but whom I wanted to keep away from (it turned out he was not that operator, it was only my imagination). I don't know why, but I was suddenly seized with the fear that Lucky had got me to this place to blackmail me later on. I recalled his persistent offers to me to join the syndicate he was part of, despite my repeated refusals.